Module 1 · Workbook answers

The Foundational Technique

Video: 43 min **Answer sheet**

This first module lays the foundation for ihsan (excellence in worship): three keys taken from Allah's words to Musa and Harun, "I am with you both; I hear and I see". Practise these three keys in your prayer and you have the base on which everything else in the course is built.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1. **What we are really looking for**

   People chase possessions, then pleasure, then fame and likes, then power, and none of them satisfies. A new phone goes out of date; on holiday you want to go home. What we really want is huḍūr (presence with Allah). This is ihsan: to worship Allah as if you see Him, and if you do not see Him, to know that He sees you. We know the hadith, but we have not truly lived it.

2. **Presence is the string of the prayer beads**

   The Qur'an criticises hearts that are distracted, and we ask Allah not to make us among the heedless. The speaker mentions Imam al-Ghazali's view that a prayer made while distracted from Allah should be repeated. Picture your worship as a string of prayer beads: salah, reciting Qur'an, dua and fasting are the beads, and presence with Allah is the string. Snap the string and all the beads fall apart.

3. **The foundation and the three keys**

   A foundation is what everything else stands on, like the fard (obligatory) prayer before the sunnah. If you only have this one lesson and truly practise it, it is enough. It comes from Surah Ta-Ha 20:46, where Allah tells Musa and Harun not to fear as they go to Pharaoh: "I am with you both; I hear and I see." From this come the three keys: Allah is seeing me, Allah is hearing me, and Allah is with me. We practise them in salat al-Isha, again and again.

4. **Key 1: Allah is seeing me**

   Use the picture that works for you. The police car behind you: suddenly your phone is down, your seat belt is on and your speed is right. A security camera in your room with a live feed to your parents. Being lost and afraid, then realising you were seen all along. Being shown on the big screen at a stadium. Allah's seeing is also loving: you are not hidden, forgotten or unimportant, and He saw the care you gave your children or your work even when no one thanked you. It changes how you move and present yourself, and Allah looks not at the stain on your clothes but at the state of your heart.

5. **Key 2: Allah is hearing me**

   Allah hears every word: "He utters no word except that with him is an observer prepared" (50:18). Imagine your phone has called your mum by accident and she hears everything you say. He hears your whisper of al-Fatiha, and He even hears your thoughts. This private talk is najwa. When the Companions asked whether Allah is near, so they should whisper, or far, so they should call out, the answer came with no "say": "I am near" (2:186). He is closer than your jugular vein (50:16), and Zakariyya called on his Lord quietly. You do not need memorised Arabic duas to talk to Allah; talk to Him like a best friend.

6 **Bringing seeing and hearing together**

Hold the picture of being seen, then send every thought that comes to you to Allah, however ordinary: a child giving you a headache, food that keeps burning, the car's MOT. This is how the Companions prayed: they talked to Allah in their salah. Other people may misunderstand you, but Allah understands everything. Ibrahim was the close friend of Allah, so why not become a friend of Allah yourself?

7 **Key 3: Allah is with me, through the dua of light**

On his way to prayer the Prophet ﷺ would ask Allah to place light in his heart, tongue, hearing and sight, and in his nerves, flesh, blood, hair, skin and bones. He was engaging with the meaning, not saying empty words. Allah shows His signs "within themselves" (41:53): you are a sign, a mini universe. Your heart beats around three billion times in a lifetime without a switch, feeding about 37 trillion cells. Your lungs, tongue, ears, eyes, brain, bones, hair, skin and blood all work without you running them. Allah is not only with you; He is running you.

8 **Your job: be present and direct it to worship**

"You're not running the show; Allah is." Your job is to fill the body with light and direct it to worship. Some of your muscles work automatically, like the heart; some are semi-automatic, like blinking and breathing; others you command, like those that take you from standing to bowing to prostration. Before you pray, go through the body in English or Arabic and become conscious of each part. In short: being seen brings physical presence, being heard settles your mind, and Allah being with you is the body He runs. Do not wait until you give the body back to realise what you were given.

From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

قَالَ لَا تَخَافَآ ۖ إِنَّنِى مَعَكُمَآ أَسْمَعُ وَأَرَىٰ

[Allah] said, "Fear not. Indeed, I am with you both; I hear and I see."

Surah Ta-Ha 20:46

> *Ihsan is that you worship Allah as though you see Him, and if you do not see Him, then indeed He sees you.*
>
> **Hadith of Jibril, Sahih Muslim and Sahih al-Bukhari**

وَإِذَا سَأَلَكَ عِبَادِى عَنِّى فَإِنِّى قَرِيبٌ ۖ أُجِيبُ دَعْوَةَ ٱلدَّاعِ إِذَا دَعَانِ ۖ فَلْيَسْتَجِيبُوا۟ لِى وَلْيُؤْمِنُوا۟ بِى لَعَلَّهُمْ يَرْشُدُونَ

And when My servants ask you, [O Muhammad], concerning Me - indeed I am near. I respond to the invocation of the supplicant when he calls upon Me. So let them respond to Me [by obedience] and believe in Me that they may be [rightly] guided.

Surah al-Baqarah 2:186

وَلَقَدْ خَلَقْنَا ٱلْإِنسَـٰنَ وَنَعْلَمُ مَا تُوَسْوِسُ بِهِۦ نَفْسُهُۥ ۖ وَنَحْنُ أَقْرَبُ إِلَيْهِ مِنْ حَبْلِ ٱلْوَرِيدِ

And We have already created man and know what his soul whispers to him, and We are closer to him than [his] jugular vein.

Surah Qaf 50:16

سَنُرِيهِمْ ءَايَٰتِنَا فِى ٱلْءَافَاقِ وَفِىٓ أَنفُسِهِمْ حَتَّىٰ يَتَبَيَّنَ لَهُمْ أَنَّهُ ٱلْحَقُّ ۗ أَوَلَمْ يَكْفِ بِرَبِّكَ أَنَّهُۥ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَىْءٍ شَهِيدٌ

We will show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the truth. But is it not sufficient concerning your Lord that He is, over all things, a Witness?

Surah Fussilat 41:53

O Allah, place light in my heart, light in my tongue, light in my hearing and light in my sight... (the dua of light the Prophet ﷺ made on his way to prayer)

Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim

Practical exercises

Key 1: feel that Allah is seeing you

1. Choose the picture that works best for you: the police car, the security camera, being lost, or the stadium screen.
2. Close your eyes and take it in: Allah is seeing you now, and has seen you since you were a child.
3. Remember one thing you did today that nobody thanked you for, and know that Allah saw it.
4. Open your eyes and write how being seen would change the way you move, dress or present yourself.

Keys 1 and 2: send your thoughts to Allah

1. Close your eyes and bring back the feeling that Allah is seeing you.
2. Let your thoughts come naturally, however ordinary they are.
3. Send each one to Allah in your own words, silently, as you would tell a best friend.
4. Write down the thoughts you sent and how it felt not to carry them alone.

Key 3: the dua of light before you pray

1. Before salah, sit for a moment and be still. Notice your heartbeat and your breath.
2. Ask Allah, in English or Arabic, to place light in your heart, tongue, hearing and sight.
3. Carry on through your brain, nerves, bones, hair, skin, blood and muscles, pausing on each one.
4. Remind yourself: Allah is running this body; my job is to be present and direct it to worship.
5. After the prayer, write which part of the body helped you feel most present.

7-day practice: the three keys

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Isha with the three keys							
Dua of light before salah							
Sent my thoughts to Allah							
Quiet time just saying "Allah"							

Reflection questions and answers

1. Which of the wrong goals (possessions, pleasure, fame, power) have you chased most, and what did it leave you feeling?

> People chase possessions, then pleasure, then fame and likes, then power, and none of them satisfies: a new phone goes out of date, and on holiday you want to go home. What we are really looking for is huḍūr (presence with Allah). For example: I have chased likes on social media most; it left me checking my phone constantly and feeling emptier each time.

2. If presence is the string that holds your worship together, how strong is your string at the moment? Where does it snap most often?

> Presence with Allah is the string of the prayer beads, and salah, Qur'an, du'a and fasting are the beads; snap the string and all the beads fall apart. A good answer looks honestly at when presence is strongest and when it is lost. For example: my string is fairly weak at the moment; it snaps most often in Isha, when I am tired and rushing to get the children to bed.

3. What thoughts do you usually carry alone that you could send to Allah instead?

> Key 2 teaches that Allah hears every word and even our thoughts, and He is closer than our jugular vein, so we can send every thought to Him, however ordinary, and talk to Him like a best friend. Other people may misunderstand us, but Allah understands everything. For example: I carry my worries about money and my mother's health alone; I could hand them to Allah in my salah instead of letting them distract me.

4. Which fact about your body moved you most, and how could you bring it to mind in your next prayer?

> Key 3 shows that Allah is not only with you; He is running you. Your heart beats around three billion times in a lifetime without a switch, feeding about 37 trillion cells, while your lungs, eyes, brain, bones, skin and blood all work without you running them. For example: the heartbeat moved me most; before my next prayer I could notice it beating and remember that Allah is keeping it going, then make the dua of light.

5. What changes when you think "Allah is running me" rather than "I am running the show"?

> "You're not running the show; Allah is." Seeing this makes our job simpler: to be present, fill the body with light and direct it to worship, rather than carrying the weight of controlling everything. For example: I would worry less about what is outside my control and feel more grateful, seeing my body as a gift I want to use well before I give it back.

My action plan

- [ ] I will pray Isha this week with the three keys: Allah is seeing me, hearing me and with me.
- [ ] I will make the dua of light before at least one prayer each day, going through my body.
- [ ] I will send my everyday thoughts and worries to Allah instead of keeping them to myself.
- [ ] I will spend a few quiet minutes alone each day just calling on Allah.
- [ ] I will share my feedback with the group before the next module on visualisation and imagination.